PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #40 · DEPRESSION

“God has forsaken me.”

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Where it often comes from

Unanswered prayer, a long depression, a loss, injustice, or a season when worship feels empty can make the soul say what the psalms also said: God has turned away. The feeling of absence is real and is not a sin by itself. The lie is the conclusion that God has broken His promise and left you for good. Depression is very good at mistaking silence for abandonment. If you are thinking about ending your life, call or text 988 in the United States, or tell someone near you right away.

What Scripture teaches

God’s own words answer this belief directly. “He will never leave you nor forsake you.” Jesus said, “Surely I am with you always, even to the end of the age.” Nothing in death or life, present or future, can separate His people from the love of God in Christ. Even in the valley of the shadow of death, the psalmist said, “You are with me.” These verses do not claim you will always feel God’s nearness. They claim that His presence does not depend on the feeling.

> *“The LORD Himself goes before you; He will be with you. He will never leave you nor forsake you. Do not be afraid or discouraged”* (Deuteronomy 31:8).

Also see

> “And teaching them to obey all that I have commanded you. And surely I am with you always, even to the end of the age” (Matthew 28:20).

> “For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor principalities, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord” (Romans 8:38–39).

> “Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil, for You are with me; Your rod and Your staff, they comfort me” (Psalm 23:4).

> “Do not fear, for I am with you; do not be afraid, for I am your God. I will strengthen you; I will surely help you; I will uphold you with My right hand of righteousness” (Isaiah 41:10).

Common self-statements

- If God were with me, I would feel Him.
- He answers other people and has given up on me.
- My prayers hit the ceiling because He left.
- This darkness means I am abandoned.
- I must have driven Him away.
- There is no point praying to someone who is gone.

Common logical errors

- Emotional reasoning: Feeling abandoned and concluding that God has left.
- Fortune telling: Deciding a quiet season is a permanent forsaking.
- Mind reading: Claiming to know that God has rejected me.
- Discounting the positive: Ignoring the promises, and the helps, that say He is still here.

Challenging questions

- Am I equating God's presence with a feeling?
- What has God promised about leaving His people?
- Have I felt forsaken before and later found He was still with me?
- What help, Scripture, or person has He already placed near me?
- Is silence the same thing as abandonment?
- What is one way I can pray honestly without deciding He is gone?

Truth summary

> Feeling abandoned is not the same as being forsaken. God has promised not to leave me, and He is with me in this.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

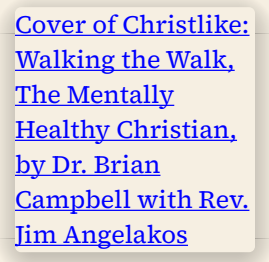
- God, All Loving
- God, Present Everywhere
- Faith
- Depression, Symptoms of
- Loneliness

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Depression
- Suffering
- Prayer

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



Cover of Christlike: Walking the Walk, The Mentally Healthy Christian, by Dr. Brian Campbell with Rev. Jim Angelakos

From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from "The Mentally Healthy Christian" (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Depression

Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Even If — MercyMe
Trust does not require the feeling you wanted before God counts as present.

Whom Shall I Fear — Chris Tomlin
God's presence gives courage without requiring a life with no darkness.

Jesus Messiah — Chris Tomlin
Jesus entered suffering. He does not stand far off from yours.

Turn Your Eyes Upon Jesus — Reawaken Hymns
When fear says God is gone, turn your eyes to Christ, who is with you.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "God has forsaken me."

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"God has forsaken me." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Am I equating God's presence with a feeling?
- ☐ What has God promised about leaving His people?
- ☐ Have I felt forsaken before and later found He was still with me?
- ☐ What help, Scripture, or person has He already placed near me?
- ☐ Is silence the same thing as abandonment?
- ☐ What is one way I can pray honestly without deciding He is gone?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Feeling abandoned is not the same as being forsaken. God has promised not to leave me, and He is with me in this.
- ☐ God will not forsake me.
- ☐ A quiet season is not the same as abandonment.
- ☐ Jesus is with me to the end of the age.
- ☐ Nothing can separate me from the love of God in Christ.
- ☐ I can pray honestly while I wait to feel Him.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Deuteronomy 31:8
  "The LORD Himself goes before you; He will be with you. He will never leave you nor forsake you. Do not be afraid or discouraged."
- ☐ Matthew 28:20
  "And teaching them to obey all that I have commanded you. And surely I am with you always, even to the end of the age."
- ☐ Romans 8:38–39
  "For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor principalities, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord."

A verse I found myself:

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ When the "God has left" feeling came: Each day, write down one moment when God felt absent. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Deuteronomy 31:8 becomes: "Sarah can write: "The Lord goes before me. He will not leave me or forsake me.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "God, Present Everywhere" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio or the Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If you are thinking about ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- ☐ Pray the promise back. Each morning, read Deuteronomy 31:8 aloud and add one honest sentence about how you feel.
- ☐ Separate feeling from promise. Write two columns: "What I feel" and "What God promised." Do not make the first column cross out the second.
- ☐ Ask one believer to pray with you once this week, especially if praying alone feels pointless.
- ☐ Get help if abandonment includes wanting to die. If you are thinking about ending your life, call or text 988, or tell someone near you today.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "God has forsaken me.": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A moment I was not forsaken
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~God has forsaken me~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I feel forsaken, and Your word says You will not leave me. Hold me to that promise. Be with me in this darkness, and give me courage to keep praying. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.